

7 Freedoms for the Wounded Left Brainer

Lets adopt this view of left vs right brain:

- Left: logical, analytical, detail-oriented, certain. Importantly: reductionist / isolated.
- Right: emotional, creative, intuitive, hearty. Importantly: holistic / relational.

Unfortunate realities of our lives can lead us to over-emphasize one side. Perhaps for a wounded left brainer:

- Mistakes were not met with charity.
- There was one shot to get things right.
- Feedback was not given, or was harsh.
- Feedback was a lecture instead of a conversation.
- Such feedback was given in common and unnoteworthy scenarios, hence uncalled for.
- Self reliance became necessary.
- The emotional environment was unpredictable.
- The list goes on...

Possible rotten fruits of these realities:

- Attempting to generate excessive certainty when making decisions or working on something.
- Excessive self reliance.
- Paranoia, OCD, perfectionism.
- Excessively avoiding calling attention to oneself.
- Seeing situations and decisions in "black and white" or "all or nothing".
- Trouble starting large projects.
- Somehow not spending time on things you care deeply about.
- The list goes on...

If any of this sounds all too familiar, these freedoms are for you.

1. Freedom to trust in the kindness and coauthorship of others.

We are around people all the time and they see us. What we permit them to perceive is another story. Whether its a large project, small project, a candid thought or reaction about the conversation, a simple behavior, habit, like, dislike, hobby, or interest- we choose whether or not to show it. If in the past showing ourselves in these ways was met with unkindness, a lack of discretion, or otherwise poor feedback, then the problems begin- especially if it was a frequent occurrence. We may choose to conceal ourselves, or wait until whatever we are working on is perfect before letting others see it. This may have been necessary for damage control at some point, but is it still necessary?

Left unchecked, we eject ourselves from the coauthorship, help, and feedback of others. We may become excessively self-reliant, anxious, or fearful. After all, everything is now up to us. As a loose analogy, consider an animal which gets separated from its pack: having lost group protection, it must become hyper-vigilant to merely survive, thus losing its ability to rest.

You are free to place trust in others. To recalibrate and stop seeing sharks where there are minnows. Of course sharks are out there, but perhaps fewer than you think. You are free to trust that when you reveal yourself, you will be met with kindness. And should something need improvement, that feedback will be charitable. You are free to be seen. You are free to trust in the coauthorship and help of others, that everything is not up to you. To work in collaboration, to give and receive slack. To live in a spirit of community.

2. Freedom to iterate, instead of having one shot to be perfect.

Now that the feedback loop is alive and kind, you are free to explore and discuss those ideas, situations, and solutions which are imperfect or not completely understood. You are free to try, make mistakes, fail, gather new information, and adjust your course along the way. And not only for a single course of action, but several over some time. Rather than planning out a single, complete, and perfect trajectory before making a move, you can send a short radial burst of investigation in several directions. This iterative process is not only permitted, but also aided by the kindness and feedback of others. Immediate perfection is not necessary. It is safe to explore and make mistakes which will be seen by others. Trust in your trajectory being confirmed or corrected with kindness.

This freedom is threefold: (1) To produce a starting point -> try it -> learn -> iterate, instead of needing to predict and produce all the way out to perfection without a trial. (2) To do this in multiple directions at once. (3) To do this with the help of others. This defeats analysis paralysis when you're literally at your wits end. Take for example the creation of any consumer product. Should you spin around endlessly thinking of the perfect design? Or might you start simple, put it in people's hands, and see what they say?

3. Freedom to strike the middle ground.

If we've been conditioned to generate excessive certainty, it may lead us to perform actions (or inactions!) and judgments which are large and sweeping. These sweeping judgments (and viewing things in black and white) shrink the world, which is helpful to make it more manageable and create certainty and safety. They may also cause us to miss or dismiss important distinctions or explorations to be had, and at great opportunity cost!

Now that we can rely on kindness and iteration, there is less need for perfection and certainty. As such you are free to take less extreme actions or inactions. You are free to break out of the "all or nothing" mindset. You are free to make moderate decisions, and see how it goes. To execute "both-and" rather than "the best" course of action.

This has endless applications. To name just a few areas of life: How much time you spend working. Frequency and length of study. How thoroughly to complete a task. How deeply to understand a concept. How frequently to socialize or rest. How close a relationship is. How intensely a relationship is pursued. How diet and exercise is viewed. How detailed a communication is. The scope of a project. How much of a task to get done in one sitting.

4. Freedom to start, step, and even stay small.

With iteration and striking the middle ground, our steps forward are smaller. Our projects can be smaller too!

Was there a time in your life when you frequently spent several hours a day in the library? And even after the most productive day, the pile of future work remained massive and daunting? Did the work truly never end? (Except by the mercy of the semester's end?) Did you frequently allow work to commandeer your entire day? Did you build some incredible projects along the way?

These big, amazing, satisfying projects came with a cost- Plowing through a boundary meant to protect our time to just be. You are free to work in smaller chunks, prioritizing time for fun and rest. You are also free to work on smaller projects, period!

To draw satisfaction from smaller steps and projects, a few things are necessary. Select only the one, most important thing to work on next. Reject working on anything less important, which tempt the completionist. More difficult however, is to reject working on the glamorous, if it would be left unleveraged without a foundation that still needs work.

Believe that small amounts of time and small projects are valuable. They are not all, but they are not nothing. Sometimes they're all you have.

5. Freedom to be a little more short sighted.

Under the oppression of generating excessive certainty, we can also attempt to predict obstacles excessively. Of course, obstacles that will clearly and obviously arise can and should be addressed. However, now that we take small steps and have an open feedback loop, we are free to stop predicting obstacles so thoroughly. Trust that presently obscured obstacles will make themselves known over time. Trust also that when they arise (1) you will be able to solve them or (2) should they be insurmountable, that you will not have wasted too much time, since your steps thus far have been small. You are free to solve problems as they arise, rather than anticipating all of them. You might switch the internal monologue from "What if?" to "Even if". Rather than saying "What if X goes wrong?" and being fearful, you can say "Even if X goes wrong, I can make a correction."

6. Freedom to seek knowledge only when necessary.

How frequently do we consume book after book, podcasts, articles, videos, inspiring speeches, quotes, etc? After all, they are incredibly interesting and might be useful some day! But how often do they make a tangible impact on your life? What if you only sought knowledge if it helped you solve a real problem in your life today?

You are free to dial back your learning. Perhaps you only need a tiny steady stream, and the occasional firehose at just the right time. Regarding someone with such concentrated effectiveness, another might say "Fear the man of one book".

Consider also relying more on the wisdom that comes from experience and error, rather than hard proven knowledge on a page. You might consider this a new form of conviction. "There are truths that at times press themselves upon us, as an experience of our entire being" [quote unknown]

7. Freedom to live from the heart.

We desire truth, goodness, and beauty. We have probably lived by, from, and out of truth quite enough. Perhaps we seek inspiring quotes, productivity strategies, or perform mental gymnastics to convince ourselves that the work before us is worth the effort - in an attempt to "think" ourselves into being productive and exercising discipline.

We need not more rules, but more heart. You are free to be motivated by beauty and emotion. To be moved by receiving the wonderful works of those before us. To reason by way of images and imagination, rather than rote analytics. To create something utterly useless, and loads of fun. You are free to enter the exchange of human hearts fearlessly.

From G. K. Chesterton:

- If you argue with a madman, it is extremely probable that you will get the worst of it; for in many ways his mind moves all the quicker for not being delayed by the things that go with good judgment. He is not hampered by a sense of humour or by charity, or by the dumb certainties of experience. He is the more logical for losing certain sane affections. Indeed, the common phrase for insanity is in this respect a misleading one. **The madman is not the man who has lost his reason. The madman is the man who has lost everything except his reason.**
-

Particularly relevant truths and lies. [John Paul II Healing Center]

- **Fear:** "In the name of Jesus Christ, I renounce the lie that if I trust I will be hurt, disappointed or die. In the name of Jesus I renounce all fear, anxiety, mistrust and distrust. I renounce the lie that I am not safe and not protected. And I announce the Truth that God is my rock, my fortress, my deliverer and my protector (see Ps 23, 27, 91). I announce the Truth that God's perfect love casts out all fear (1 Jn. 4:18). I announce the Truth that I am safe and secure."
- **Confusion:** "In the name of Jesus Christ, I renounce the lie that everything is confusing, that I don't understand anything and that it is up to me to figure things out on my own. In Jesus name, I announce the truth that I have the mind of Christ (1 Co. 2:16) and that the Holy Spirit reveals whatever I need to know when I need to know it (1 Co. 1:7). I announce the truth that the Lord gives wisdom and understanding to anyone who asks (Jas 1: 5). I announce the Truth that God has given His Church to lead me into all Truth. I announce the Truth that I have understanding and enlightenment from the Lord."